and other religio-economic establishments such as temples (see below) had come up along important overland routes of communication during the first millennium CE, helping travelers to traverse the difficult terrain connecting Eurasia and the Indian subcontinent.[20] It was precisely the economic vibrancy of the region that had attracted Muslim military adventurers of the eighth–ninth centuries, who staked claims of control over pockets within the region. Similarly, the emergence of the Hindu-shahi rulers (*c.* 843–1026 CE) of Udabhandapura (near modern Attock on the Indus) – followers mainly of the Shaivite sects of Brahmanical Hinduism (cf. Chapter 1) – also relied on the economic networks of commerce and pilgrimage throughout ancient Gandhara and Swat to build their empire.[21]

The ascendancy of the Ghaznavids in Zabulistan by the end of the tenth century, and their eastward expansion shortly thereafter, brought the Gandhara–Swat region within the sights of Sultan Mahmud not only for its economic offerings, but also due to its function as one of the principal conduits into the north Indian plains. The region's midway position between the Khyber Pass and northern India ultimately rendered it an important waystation for the Ghaznavids, where there was little resistance to their entry, especially after the final defeat of the Hindu-shahi Anandapala in AH 400/1010 CE: certainly, this is the impression gleaned from the Ghaznavid sources' scanty mention of campaigns into Swat, and equally so from their architectural traces. Udegram's terraced Rajagira mosque and its small surrounding settlement (Figure 6.2) are among the few known Ghaznavid-period remnants in the region. Commanding a spectacular view of the valley below, the mosque of "Gandharan" masonry (Figure 6.3) – slabs of local schist in mortar – formed a continuation with the building methods employed in the region's Buddhist monasteries since the early centuries of the common era.[22]

Toward the southwest leading to the Panjab, at the southern limits of historical Gandhara, Ghaznavid-period authors enumerated several military confrontations specifically between Sultan Mahmud and Hindu-shahi rulers. Although no Ghaznavid-period architectural traces have definitively been identified in the area,[23] a distinct and enduring style of temple architecture – spanning the sixth–seventh through eleventh centuries and largely developed *via* Hindu-shahi patronage – was clearly in evidence. The Ghazna Shansabanis' campaign to Peshawar and beyond, then, brought Mu'izz al-Din and his forces into the erstwhile Hindu-shahi territories and surely included encounters with their architectural remains.

The scholarship of Michael Meister[24] has been seminal in understanding the architectural developments in the Salt and Hissar mountain ranges, spanning the modern Pakistani provinces of eastern Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa and West Panjab – the latter's historical extent reaching southward to the middle Indus around Multan. Meister convincingly posited the distinctiveness of this regional school of temple architecture, which he called